

U.S. fuel prices altering travel plans

Americans still expect to take trips but opt for cheaper ones amid inflationary pressures.

By Rio Yamat

As someone who is “not the best person with bugs and stuff,” Stephanie Bernaba never imagined herself becoming an outdoorsy mom.

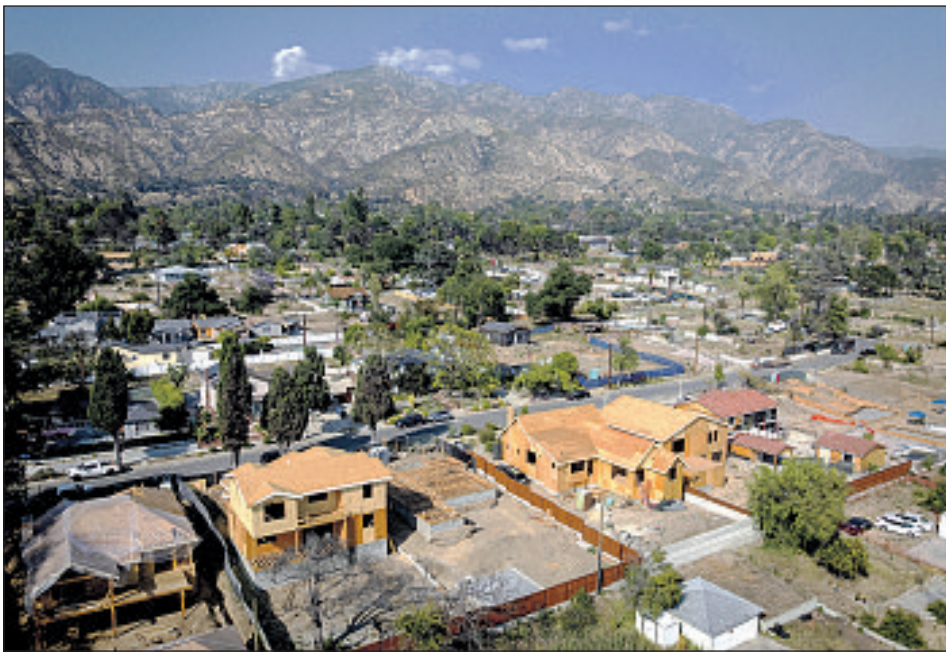
But the mother of three is getting more daring as gas prices and other travel costs make vacations more expensive. Her family has traded pricier trips, such as long summer stays in Florida and an annual Disney World visit around her birthday, for local beaches, bike rides and hiking trails near their home in coastal Rhode Island.

“I’ve been trying to do more of that because one, it’s quality time. Two, it’s fresh air. And three, we’re not spending an arm and a leg,” Bernaba, 47, said.

That kind of calibration is shaping the summer travel season, which gets its traditional start in the U.S. with the long Memorial Day holiday weekend. Higher fuel prices resulting from the Iran war and other inflationary pressures are making most forms of travel costlier as people in many parts of the world form their plans.

The U.S. Travel Assn. expects annual travel spending to grow by a modest 1% this year, powered largely by domestic leisure travel despite the FIFA World Cup giving soccer fans from other countries a reason to visit the U.S. Airfares have climbed around the world along with the price of jet fuel as the war constrains global oil supplies.

Sticking closer to home may not cushion the sticker shock. The nonprofit Institute on Taxation and Economic Policy estimated Americans would collectively spend an extra \$3.5 billion on gasoline over the holiday weekend. The average price [See Travel, A11]



Photographs by ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

HOMES are being built, at top, along Laurel Drive. Above is the burned lot that belongs to Crystal Nerone, who now sees the benefits that investors can provide.

Once shunned, investors gain support in Altadena

Some are lauded for helping the community rebuild

By Doug Smith

They watched with alarm as a developer known for building boxy duplexes in South Los Angeles started buying lots on their block in west Altadena.

One in March, one in April, one in May. One in September.

For Michael and Crystal Nerone, who were weighing the pros and cons of rebuilding their house destroyed in the Eaton fire, the prospect of four two-story rentals on their street was tilting the scale toward flight.

The Nerones had at-

tended community meetings where outside investors — and in particular the one buying up their block — were assailed for grabbing lots at literal fire-sale prices, presumably to replace destroyed bungalows and cottages with hulking mansions and multifamily rentals.

When Ocean Development Inc. bought a fifth lot, the one next to theirs, the Nerones might have been ready to call it quits. But Crystal decided to give the company a chance to explain its intentions.

She placed a call that has turned her view of investors upside down. To her surprise, Kip Cyprus, Ocean Development’s general contractor, called right back.

“He said I could look at the house he already built,” she said. “He gave me the address and told me how to get in. I did.”

She drove to Highview Avenue and saw a house that had curb appeal, sophisticated landscaping and interior details like handmade cabinets that she would [See Recovery, A8]

GOP senators defy Trump on ‘slush fund’

\$1.8-billion pot is last straw for some as they block money for immigration efforts.

By Ana Ceballos and Justine McDaniel

WASHINGTON — President Trump’s grip on his party slipped on Thursday as anger boiled over among Senate Republicans about a growing list of issues.

In a striking display of defiance, GOP senators abruptly derailed plans to vote on legislation to fund Trump’s immigration crackdown amid deep disagreements over security funding for a White House ballroom and a \$1.8-billion fund to pay people who claim to have been politically persecuted.

The discontent had been building for weeks. Many senators had grown frustrated over Trump’s decision to endorse candidates running against longtime Republican incumbents.

Others, worried about rising costs as a result from the war in Iran, had aired concerns ahead of the midterm elections. But the breaking point came when the Justice Department, with little warning, pushed to create what it termed the “anti-weaponization fund.”

Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-S.D.) acknowledged the concerns over the fund Thursday after

a reportedly contentious private meeting about it between Senate Republicans and acting Atty. Gen. Todd Blanche. He also conceded midterm politics had added to the tension.

“It’s hard to divorce anything that happens here from what’s happening in the political atmosphere around us,” Thune told reporters. “You can’t disconnect those things.”

A day earlier, Sen. Bill Cassidy, a Louisiana Republican who lost his primary race on Saturday to a Trump-backed challenger, expressed strong disagreement with the creation of the fund, which would be controlled by appointees without congressional oversight.

“People are concerned about paying their mortgage or rent, affording groceries and paying for gas, not putting together a \$1.8 billion fund for the president and his allies to pay whom-ever they wish with no legal precedent or accountability,” Cassidy wrote on X. “If there needs to be a settlement, the administration should bring it to Congress to decide.”

Sen. Mitch McConnell (R-Ky.) also had harsh criticism for the fund.

“So the nation’s top law enforcement official is asking for a slush fund to pay people who assault cops? Utterly stupid, morally wrong — take your pick,” he said in a statement.

[See Senators, A8]

Pratt, on the attack, jolts mayoral race

Reality TV antagonist turns his personal loss in Palisades fire into a run for office in L.A.

By David Zahniser, Connor Sheets, Noah Haggerty and Yvonne Villarreal

Los Angeles voters watched as wildfire destroyed thousands of homes. They mourned the loss of entertainment industry jobs and despaired over homeless people living in squalor.

Now, a former reality television villain who lost his home in the Palisades fire is using his Hollywood savvy, social media skills and his innate rage to harness those emotions, emerging as an unexpected and polarizing contender in the mayor’s race.

Spencer Pratt of MTV’s reality soap “The Hills” has turned a sleepy citywide contest into a national story, outpacing his rivals in fundraising, putting in an assured debate performance and ranking near the top of voter surveys.

L.A. has never seen a mayoral candidate quite like

Pratt, a scathing critic of City Hall who has depicted its streets as a dystopian hellscape menaced by drug-addicted zombies. He has vowed a scorched-earth policy for those who might block his vision for clearing away the unhouised.

Pratt has picked up campaign donations from Democratic Party megadonor Haim Saban and Universal Music Group Chairman and Chief Executive Lucian Grainge, one of the most powerful men in the music business. A registered Republican, he has won praise from media figures aligned with President Trump, including podcaster Joe Rogan and Fox News host Greg Gutfeld.

Trump himself offered words of support on Wednesday, saying: “I heard he’s a big MAGA person.”

Pratt has downplayed his party affiliation, pointing out that the mayor’s race is nonpartisan. He repeatedly declined to comment for this story, including when approached at a campaign event Wednesday.

“He’s an outsider candidate. He’s a celebrity candidate. He’s very clever, very strategic, and very skilled at social media,” said Republi- [See Pratt, A6]

Cuba warns its citizens to prepare for war

Amid rising pressure, Rubio says likelihood of ‘peaceful’ accord with nation isn’t high.

By Kate Linticum

MEXICO CITY — In recent days, the U.S. Navy stationed an aircraft carrier off the coast of Cuba, the White House expanded sanctions on Havana’s leaders and federal prosecutors charged former Cuban President Raúl Castro with murder.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio, speaking to reporters, said what to many is be-



RAMON ESPINOSA Associated Press

IMAGES of Cuban leaders, including the late Fidel Castro, right, at a government building in Havana.

coming obvious: that the likelihood of a “negotiated and peaceful agreement” with Cuba’s communist government is “not high.”

Months into a punishing oil blockade that has triggered widespread blackouts on the island, the Trump administration has ratcheted up its pressure campaign against Havana even further, raising questions about whether Cuba will be the next U.S. target after Venezuela and Iran. The U.S. overthrew Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro in January and a month later killed Iran’s supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. [See Cuba, A3]

The men who gave their lives to stop San Diego mosque assault

By Suhauna Hussain, Richard Winton and Hannah Fry

SAN DIEGO — In the moments that gunmen opened fire at the Islamic Center of San Diego, the actions of three men staved off an even more extensive tragedy.

Authorities say that, before they were killed Monday, they slowed the shooters, sent out a warning and alerted police, allowing doz-

ens of schoolchildren inside the mosque to scramble for safety.

They’re now hailed as heroes: a security guard with a winning smile, a storekeeper known for his lentil soup and the husband of a schoolteacher whose proud daughter said that when he heard gunfire, he ran toward it.

“I want to be clear: All three of our victims did not die in vain,” San Diego Police Chief Scott Wahl said. “Without question, there would have been many more

fatalities [that day].”

All three were deeply familiar faces at the mosque, even for those who did not have personal relationships with them. Tens of thousands of dollars in donations have poured into a fundraiser set up for their families.

“We lost three pillars of our community,” the imam, or leader of the mosque, Taha Hassane, said. “We call them our martyrs and our heroes.”

[See Mosque, A5]

L.A. City Council approves budget

\$15-billion spending plan seeks more police officers and funding in case of emergencies. CALIFORNIA, B1

SpaceX shoots for stars in IPO

The stock offering could raise at least \$75 billion and give firm a market value of up to \$2 trillion. BUSINESS, A10

Weather Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 75/58. B6



R.J. SANGOSTI Denver Post

DIRE WATER SHORTAGE

Rings at Lake Powell show how far it has receded as climate change has led to a deficit in Colorado River water for Western states. CLIMATE, A9